



Paralysis

The main symptom of paralysis is loss of voluntary control of movement in part of the body. It is classified by the areas of the body affected. Sometimes only one muscle or a small muscle group is affected, but paralysis can also be total, resulting in complete loss of motor function. It can be intermittent or permanently disabling.

Paralysis may affect any part of the body, including the face, the hands, one arm or leg (monoplegia), one side of the body (hemiplegia), both legs (paraplegia), and both arms and legs (tetraplegia or quadriplegia). The body may also become stiff or rigid (spastic paralysis) with occasional muscle spasms, or floppy (flaccid paralysis).

Main causes of paralysis

Paralysis can result from an injury, or be caused by many different disorders, each of which requires specialist assessment. A stroke

or transient ischemic attack (see p.199) can lead to sudden weakness on one side of the face, weakness in one arm, or slurred speech. Bell's Palsy is an abrupt weakness that affects one side of the face, along with earache or face pain.

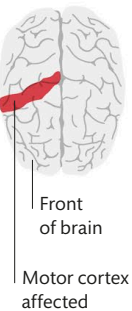
In addition, severe head or spinal-cord injury can trigger paralysis, while multiple sclerosis or myasthenia gravis—a disease that affects the junction between nerves and skeletal muscles—can cause weakness in the face, arms, or legs that comes and goes. Other causes of paralysis include brain

WHAT IS THE MOST COMMON CAUSE OF PARALYSIS?

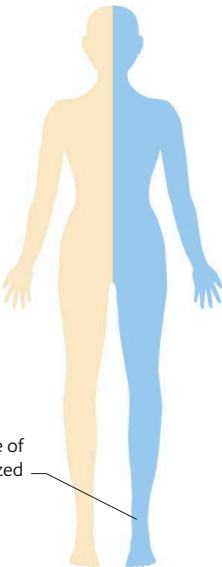
In the US, the most common trigger is stroke, followed by spinal-cord injuries and multiple sclerosis.

tumors, Guillain-Barré syndrome, cerebral palsy, and spina bifida. Tick-borne Lyme disease causes paralysis that may begin weeks, months, or years after the initial tick bite.

OVERHEAD VIEW



Opposite side of body paralyzed

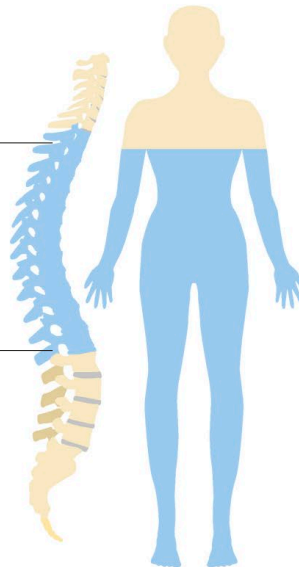


Hemiplegia

Paralysis affects one side of the body, often seen as a result of stroke or brain tumor affecting the motor cortex. Hemiplegia may also be caused by a brain trauma.

Thoracic vertebra 1

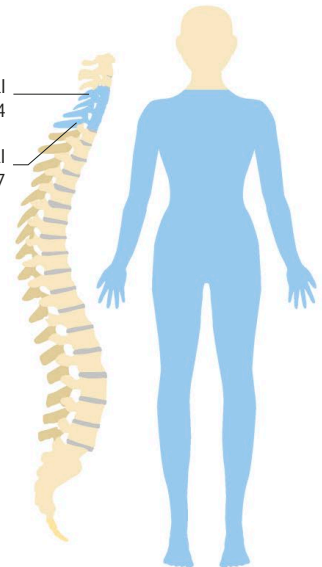
Lumbar vertebra 1



Paraplegia

Paralysis affects the legs, and sometimes part of the trunk, usually due to a spinal injury, but it can arise from traumatic brain damage or a medical condition such as a spinal or brain tumor or spina bifida.

Cervical vertebra 4
Cervical vertebra 7



Quadriplegia

Also known as tetraplegia, both arms and legs are partially or completely paralyzed, as is the body from the neck down, usually as a result of a break to the lower part of the neck.